ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Language, Power and Society

University of Glasgow

Semantics

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Week 7

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Who decides what a word means?

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Is a Jaffa Cake a cake or a biscuit?

- In the UK, cakes are zero-rated for VAT; chocolate-covered biscuits are taxed at the standard rate
- McVitie's argued before a VAT tribunal in 1991 that Jaffa Cakes are cakes
  - A cake goes hard when it is stale; a biscuit goes soft
  - McVitie's baked a giant Jaffa Cake for the tribunal to make the point
- The tribunal agreed: a Jaffa Cake is a cake, and carries no VAT

Association of Taxation Technicians, "VAT treatment of Jaffa Cakes explained"

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Is Subway's bread *bread*?

- Irish VAT law zero-rates bread, defined as containing sugar or fat of no more than 2% of the weight of the flour
- Subway's rolls contained sugar at about 10% of the weight of the flour
- The Irish Supreme Court ruled in 2020 that they are not "bread" for VAT purposes, so they are taxed

Bookfinders Ltd v The Revenue Commissioners [2020] IESC 60

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Is a burrito a sandwich?

- Panera Bread's lease at a shopping centre in Massachusetts barred the landlord from renting to another restaurant selling more than 10% sandwiches
- The landlord then rented a unit to Qdoba, which sells burritos, tacos and quesadillas
- Panera went to court, arguing that a burrito is a sandwich

"two thin pieces of bread, usually buttered, with a thin layer (as of meat, cheese, or savory mixture) spread between them"

Webster's Third New International Dictionary, s.v. *sandwich*, as cited by the court

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Is a burrito a sandwich?

"A sandwich is not commonly understood to include burritos, tacos, and quesadillas, which are typically made with a single tortilla and stuffed with a choice filling of meat, rice, and beans."

Judge Jeffrey Locke, *White City Shopping Center, LP v PR Restaurants, LLC* (Mass. Super. Ct., 31 October 2006)

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Is a burrito a sandwich? In Indiana, yes

- In 2024 a judge in Indiana ruled the other way
- A planning agreement allowed a restaurant selling made-to-order, Subway-style sandwiches
- A Mexican restaurant applied; the judge held that tacos and burritos are sandwiches

Quintana v Fort Wayne Plan Commission (May 2024)

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Can a veggie burger be a *steak*?

- In March 2026, EU negotiators agreed to reserve 31 meat terms for meat products
  - Not allowed on plant-based products: *steak*, *bacon*, *chicken*, *beef*, *pork*
  - Still allowed: *burger*, *sausage*, *nuggets*

Provisional agreement of 5 March 2026 (European Parliament, Council of the EU and European Commission)

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Meaning and power

"How does one meaning gain dominance over all others? [...] those with meaning-making power [...] attempt to 'naturalize' their own ideologies about the social category a given label denotes."

Campbell-Kibler et al. (2002: 9)

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The LPA toolbox



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Semantics

Four tools for analysing how a text persuades:

Transitivity	who does what to whom
Modality	how certain, or how obliged, something is presented as being
Presupposition	what a text takes for granted
Semantics	**which words are chosen to name and describe, and what those words carry with them**

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Names and Labels

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Denotation and connotation

- **Denotation**: what a word refers to, and the conditions something must meet to count as one
- **Connotation**: the associations and attitudes a word carries from the ways it is used
- Two words can share a denotation and differ in connotation

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spinster, bachelor, playboy

student

girlfriend, wife

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Partners

- *husband, wife*
- *common-law husband, common-law wife*
- *boyfriend, girlfriend*
- *lover*
- *other half*
- *significant other*
- *him indoors, her indoors*
- *cohabitee*
- *bidie-in*
- *partner*
- *situationship*
- *talking stage*

> Which would you put on an official form? Which would you use in front of your gran?

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Pejoratives and Reclamation

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Pejoratives

- A **pejorative** is a word or expression with negative connotations: *control freak*, *lazy*, *slipshod*, *nerd*, *Karen*

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Bill Watterson, *Calvin and Hobbes*

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Reclamation

- **Reclamation**: a group takes over a word used against it and uses it of itself
- *queer → Queer Studies*

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Avoiding Connotations

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Avoiding connotations

Euphemism | Dysphemism | Jargon

Register | Metaphor

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Euphemism

- A **euphemism** is chosen to avoid a word that would be taboo, upsetting, rude or face-threatening

mathematically challenged

passed away

let go

between jobs

Ange Postecoglou has been "relieved of his duties as head coach with immediate effect"

Nottingham Forest's statement, 18 October 2025, after 39 days in the job

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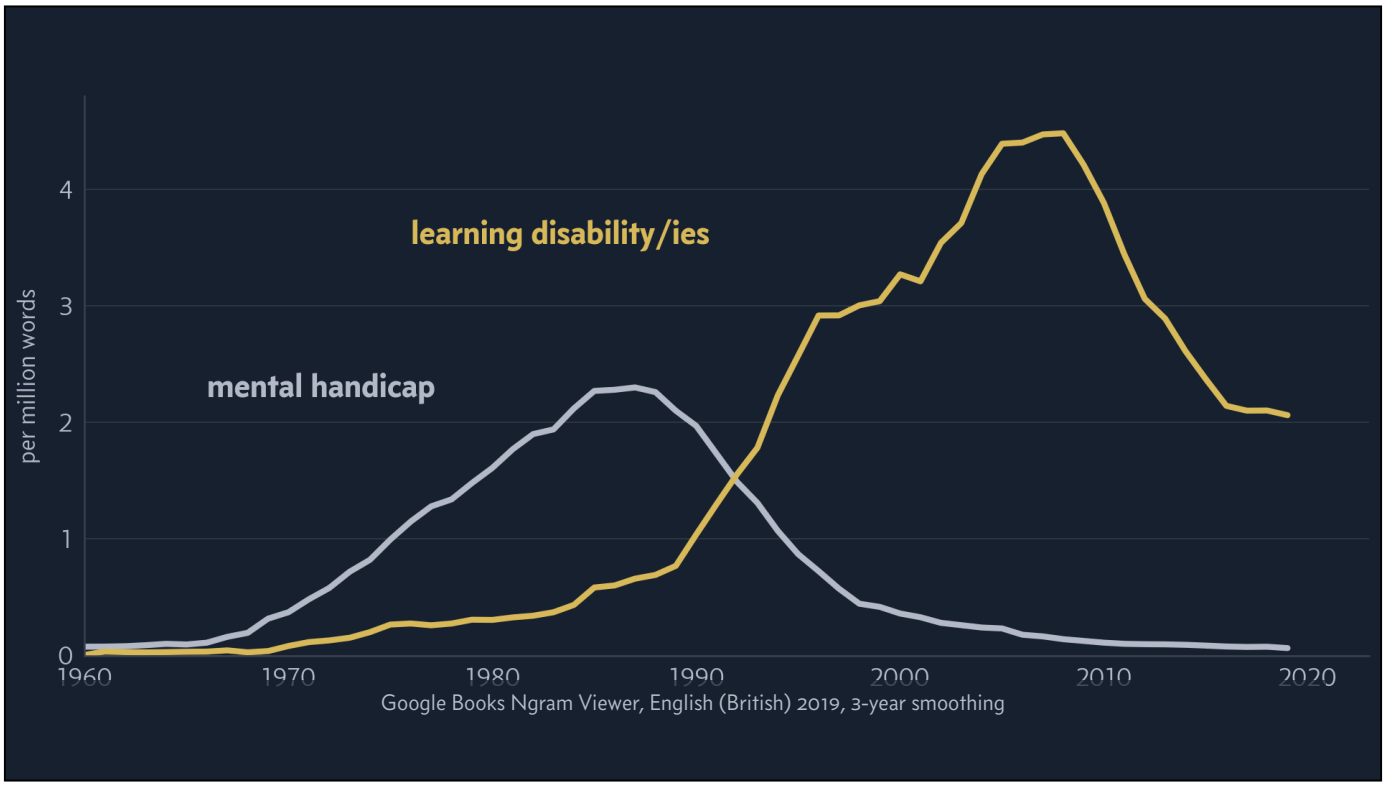
Stephan Pastis, *Pearls Before Swine*

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The euphemism treadmill

- A euphemism picks up the connotations of the thing it names, and in time needs replacing itself
- Pinker (1994) traces *water closet* → *toilet* → *bathroom* → *rest room*

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Dysphemism

- A **dysphemism** is chosen for more negative connotations than the neutral word: to offend, to shock or to amuse

bit the dust

finished off

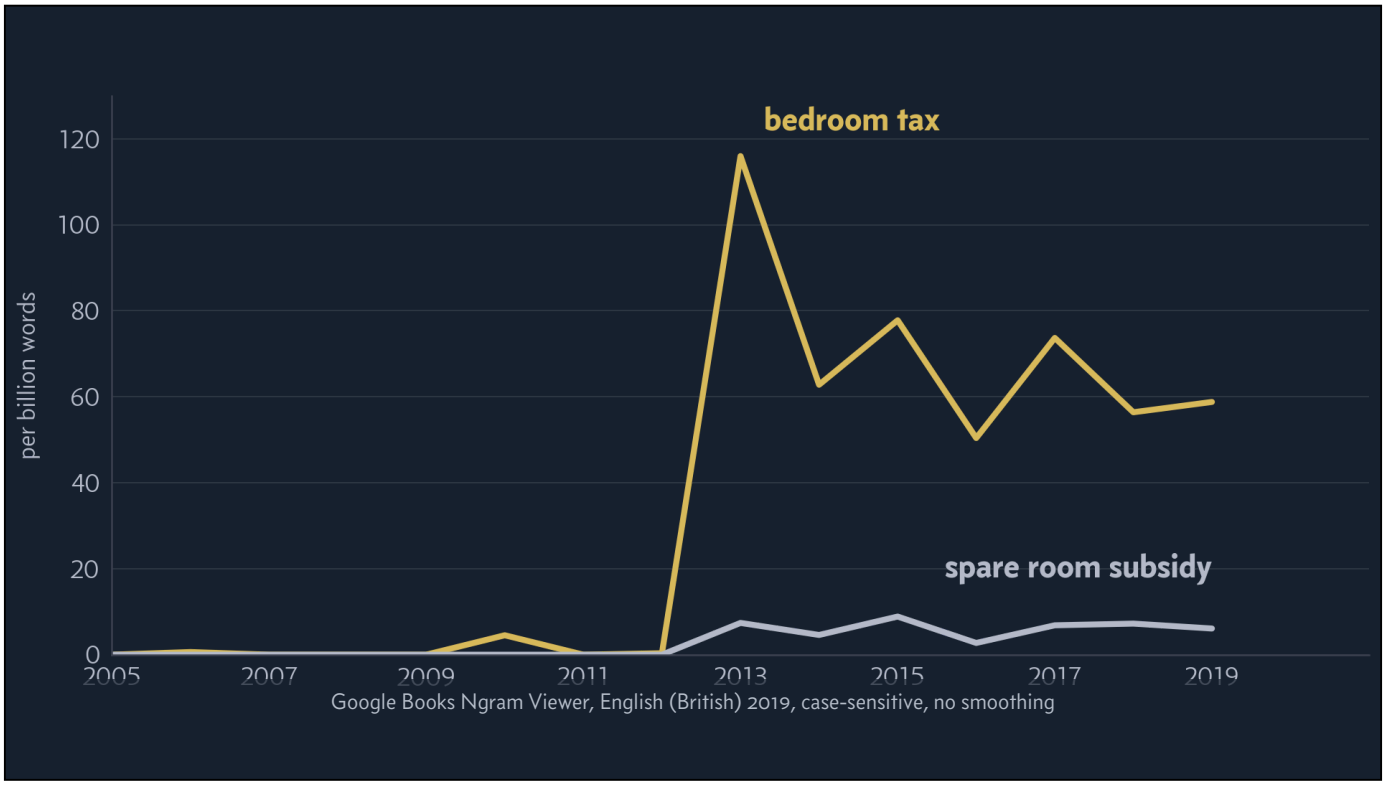
clankers (robots and AI)

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Name the policy, name the tax

Label	Used by	The policy's own name
death tax (2010)	Conservatives	funding for a National Care Service
bedroom tax (2013)	Labour and other critics	removal of the spare room subsidy
dementia tax (2017)	Labour and other critics	the 2017 Conservative manifesto's social care plan
family farm tax (2024)	Conservatives	changes to agricultural property relief

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Jargon

- **Jargon** is the vocabulary of a profession or other group; to outsiders it can sound grander or more evasive than ordinary words

rodent exterminator

cabin service director

collateral damage

special military operation

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Register

- **Register**: technical, everyday or slang; formal or informal

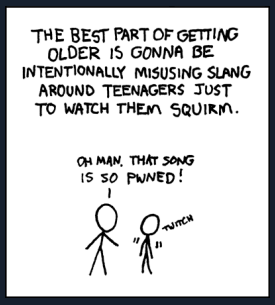
This phone is fast.

This phone has an octa-core processor and 12 GB of RAM.

This phone is pure rapid, ngl.

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Register



- *67*: Dictionary.com's Word of the Year 2025
- *unc*: on Dictionary.com's 2026 shortlist

Randall Munroe, *xkcd* (CC BY-NC 2.5)

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Metaphor

- A **metaphor** describes one area of experience in terms of another

> DISEASE IS WAR: *fight off an infection*, *give in to the flu*, *battle cancer*

- For some people with cancer, war metaphors meant failure; for others, strength (Semino et al. 2017)

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Metaphor

IDEAS ARE PLANTS

Communal mentality and shared responsibility are **flourishing** beliefs in many cultures. These ideas are **planted** very early in the minds of children. They are further **cultivated** both in the family and in the social life. Very soon, **deeply rooted** beliefs are **grown**.

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Stereotype

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Stereotype

- A **stereotype** is a socially constructed 'typical' member of a category of people
- Stereotypes become a problem when attitudes or biases are based on them

> Successful lawyers earn a lot of money, and after winning a case **he** wants to celebrate in style.
>
> Any secretary you care to name will work hard for **her** pay.
>
> According to disapproving church writers, the Vikings were addicted to drink, gluttony and **women**.

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Stereotype

> A father and his son are in a car crash. The father dies at the scene. The son is rushed to hospital, and the surgeon on duty looks at him and says, "I can't operate on this boy. He's my son."
>
> **Who is the surgeon?**

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Most direct to least direct

sacked

fired

let go

parted company by mutual consent

relieved of his duties

> With a neighbour: rank these.

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Next weeks

- Week 8: Language and Politics
- Week 9: Verbal Hygiene

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Reading

- The semantics section of your LPA booklet
- Simpson (1993)
- Optional: Jeffries (2010), chapter 2, “Naming and describing”

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References

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Pinker, Steven. 1994. The game of the name. *The New York Times*, 5 April 1994.

Semino, Elena, Zsófia Demjén, Jane Demmen, Veronika Koller, Sheila Payne, Andrew Hardie & Paul Rayson. 2017. The online use of Violence and Journey metaphors by patients with cancer, as compared with health professionals: A mixed methods study. *BMJ Supportive & Palliative Care* 7(1). 60–66.

Simpson, Paul. 1993. *Language, ideology and point of view*. London: Routledge.

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